Japan trip pre-arrival checklist

Free, no signup. Generated 2026-11-03 from the official-source rules behind the free Japan tools at free-agent-tools.vercel.app. Rules change: tap each "Check yours" link before you travel.

Before you fly

☐ TB screening: who needs it

- Nationals of the Philippines, Viet Nam, Indonesia, Nepal, Myanmar and China who intend to enter and stay in Japan as mid- to long-term residents (period of stay over 3 months; not Temporary Visitor, Diplomat or Official), excluding re-entry permit holders, plus Designated Activities No. 53 (Digital Nomad) and No. 54 (their spouse or child).

Check yours: japan-tb-screening.vercel.app · rules as of 2026-10-15 · official: www.mhlw.go.jp · philippines.iom.int · nhsgroup.ph

☐ Driving in Japan

- 1949 Geneva Convention IDP from a party that issues the Geneva format (+ home license). Vienna-format IDPs are not valid.
- License from Switzerland, Germany, France, Belgium, Monaco or Taiwan + Japanese translation by the issuing authority/embassy, JAF, 訪日運転者支援協会, ADAC (Germany) or 台湾日本関係協会 / ZIPLUS (Taiwan).
- Up to 1 year counted from the landing date, but not past the IDP's validity (1 year from issue) or the home license's expiry.

Check yours: japan-driving-check.vercel.app · rules as of 2026-10-27 · official: www.npa.go.jp · www.keishicho.metro.tokyo.lg.jp · english.jaf.or.jp

☐ Bringing a pet

- Dogs and cats need a microchip, rabies shots, an antibody test and advance notice; from most countries the process takes months. Check your route on the tool before booking.

Check yours: japan-pet-quarantine.vercel.app · rules as of 2026-10-31 · official: www.maff.go.jp · laws.e-gov.go.jp

At arrival

☐ Duty-free allowance per adult

- Alcohol: 3 bottles of about 760 ml.
- Cigarettes: 200; cigars: 50; heat-not-burn: 10 packages.
- Perfume: 2 oz (about 56 ml). Eau de toilette / eau de cologne not included.
- Other goods: ¥200,000 total overseas value. An item kind whose total overseas value is ¥10,000 or less is free and not counted toward ¥200,000.
- Cash and other means of payment over ¥1,000,000: declare on the "Declaration of Carrying of Means of Payment, etc.".

Check yours: japan-customs-allowance.vercel.app · rules as of 2026-10-14 · official: www.customs.go.jp

Getting around

☐ Big suitcases on the Shinkansen

- Bags with total length + width + height of 161–250 cm need a reserved 'seat with an oversized baggage area' (last row) or oversized-baggage compartment seat; no extra charge beyond a reserved-seat ticket. Without a reservation staff can charge ¥1,000 (tax incl.) and move the bag. Over 250 cm cannot be brought on board.

Check yours: japan-luggage.vercel.app · rules as of 2026-10-12 · official: www.kuronekoyamato.co.jp · global.jr-central.co.jp · www.westjr.co.jp

☐ Visitor vs resident prices

- Dual pricing in Japan is legal and set by each facility; the Japan Tourism Agency (観光庁) runs a study group (first meeting 2026-04-27) and plans guidelines for public facilities within FY2026 (by March 2027).
- The test is almost always residence (registered address in the city/prefecture, or living in Japan), not nationality. Foreign residents with a registered address pay the resident price; Japanese visitors from other cities pay the higher price.

Check yours: japan-dual-pricing.vercel.app · rules as of 2026-10-16 · official: visit-himeji.com · www.mlit.go.jp · www.jiji.com

Safety

☐ Weather warning levels

- Since 2026-05-29 Japan's heavy-rain, flood, landslide and storm-surge warnings carry the alert level in their name: Level 5 特別警報 Emergency Warning (black), Level 4 危険警報 Urgent Warning (purple, new), Level 3 警報 Warning (red), Level 2 注意報 Advisory (yellow), Level 1 早期注意情報 Early Advisory (white). Evacuate by Level 4. Earthquake Early Warnings, tsunami warnings, Nankai Trough information, J-ALERT and the other weather warnings keep their names.

Check yours: japan-alert-decoder.vercel.app · rules as of 2026-10-17 · official: www.jma.go.jp · www.data.jma.go.jp · www.bousai.go.jp

Shopping and leaving

☐ Tax-free shopping (refund method)

- Japan's tax-free shopping for visitors switches on 2026-11-01 from tax-off-at-the-till to a refund method: pay the tax-inclusive price, get the consumption tax back after customs confirms on departure (before checking bags) within 90 days of purchase.
- Bring the passport you showed at purchase (cruise passengers and crew: also the landing permit).
- Each store's purchases are added up per day: you need ¥5,000+ before tax at one store on one day.
- Register your refund method (card, app, etc.) at the shop when you buy; ask how and when they pay.
- Depart Japan within 90 days of the purchase date (counted from the day after purchase).
- Do the tax-free kiosk (or Visit Japan Web at Narita, Haneda, Kansai, Chubu, New Chitose, Fukuoka, Naha) at your FINAL departure airport or seaport, BEFORE checking bags. Checked bags cannot be retrieved for this.
- Carry every item from each receipt. If one item from a receipt is missing, nothing on that receipt is refunded.
- Take all tax-free goods, general goods and consumables alike, out of Japan unused. Food, drinks, and cosmetics used in Japan are not refundable; if you used some, skip the kiosk and tell the customs counter.
- Green result: done. Red result: take the goods to the customs inspection area before boarding. Leave plenty of time; missing your flight is not compensated.
- Items costing ¥1,000,000+ before tax: bring the certificate of authenticity or warranty.
- Export the goods without delay after customs confirms them, or the tax is collected back and penalties apply.

Check yours: japan-tax-free-refund.vercel.app · rules as of 2026-10-09 · official: www.japan.travel · www.mlit.go.jp · www.nta.go.jp

Educational summaries, not legal, tax or immigration advice. Rules change; confirm with the official source linked for each rule before relying on it.